Repair or Replace?

A calm two-question card to keep by your mending basket. It won't tell you what to do — it just makes the decision quicker and kinder.

Question 1: Is it fixable?

USUALLY FIXABLE	USUALLY NOT WORTH FIXING
Loose or missing buttons	Melted, burned, or chemically stained areas
Fallen hems or loose seams	Rotted or brittle fabric anywhere you touch
Small holes, tears, worn knees	Zipper tape that's shredded or both sliders broken at once
Broken zippers (see Zipper Smarts)	Mold or an unidentifiable smell
Stretched collars or cuffs	Items that no longer fit your life
Split tote bag or backpack straps	
Snapped straps or drawstrings	

Question 2: Would the work be more than the item is worth?

Try this quick math instead of agonizing:

1. **Time it saves:** if the fix takes under 20 minutes, the “worth” hurdle is almost always cleared. Most of our mends live here.
2. **Heart it costs:** if it's a favorite, a gift, or hard to replace in your color, add that to the value side. Sentiment counts. Favorites usually save you a shopping trip you'd rather skip anyway.
3. **Cost it saves:** a tailor's hem costs about the same as a pizza. Sewing it yourself tonight costs a bit of thread and one episode of your show.
4. **Burden it shrinks:** a drawer of “maybe someday” broken things is a mental tax. Pick the best two, fix those, and release the rest without guilt.

> **The 20-minute rule:** if you can finish it before dinner, do it now while the tea's hot. If you can't, schedule it — a mend that waits a week is a mend that usually waits a year.

Keep this card

Tape it inside a closet door or slide it into your sewing kit lid. The point isn't to be efficient — it's to stop dreading the little pile.

When in doubt

Fix it. A slightly wonky mend on a comfortable, loved thing beats a brand-new replacement you had to go out and shop for. Wonky mends soften with wash and wear.

Kind tips: Release items with gratitude and without guilt. If you've never missed it, it was never in the way.